

Required Readings and Discussion Questions

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October 2026

Theory and Stata are part of every lecture. Paper discussions take place in lectures 2, 4, 6 and 8. Read the stated sections before the meeting, bring short notes on the questions, and flag passages you do not understand.

Lecture 2: Friday 9 October

Law and Economics focus: deterrence, sanctions, incomplete contracts and behavioural responses to enforcement.

Gneezy, U. and Rustichini, A. (2000), A fine is a price, *Journal of Legal Studies* 29(1): 1–17, doi:10.1086/468061

[Read the paper \(free PDF\)](#)

Read the abstract, Section I and Section II (printed pp. 1–5), inspect Table 1 (p. 6) and Figure 1 (p. 7). Skip formal tests and the theoretical model at this stage.

Preparation: 30–45 minutes. Bring brief notes on the three questions; no graded reading submission.

- What does one row of Table 1 record, and what does one cell count? What does Figure 1 average?
- Which centres receive the fine, how were they chosen, and in which weeks is it in force?
- Why are the 200 centre-week counts not 200 independent observations of the effect of the fine?

Lecture 4: Friday 16 October

Law and Economics focus: judicial institutions, legal protections and realised prosecutorial independence.

Voigt, S. and Wulf, A. J. (2019; first online 2017), What makes prosecutors independent? Analysing the institutional determinants of prosecutorial independence, *Journal of Institutional Economics* 15(1): 99–120

[Read the paper; author-uploaded version.](#) Publisher access may require an institutional login.

Read the abstract, Section 1 and Section 5; inspect Table 1 and only column (1) of Table 2, especially the English legal-origin row and the footnotes. Other specifications are for lecture 6.

Preparation: 35–45 minutes. Bring a one-sentence question, the outcome definition and one coefficient interpretation.

- What distinguishes de jure from de facto independence, and what is the observational unit?
- What does the English legal-origin coefficient compare, and on which scale?
- Why is this adjusted coefficient different from an unconditional difference of group means?

Lecture 6: Friday 23 October

Law and Economics focus: evaluating claims about institutional determinants and the effectiveness of legal protections.

Voigt and Wulf (2019; first online 2017), same paper, second reading

[Read the paper](#); [author-uploaded version](#). Publisher access may require an institutional login.

Read Sections 7 and 8; inspect all five columns of Table 2 and its footnotes; revisit Section 5 only where needed. Focus on regressors, uncertainty and changing samples.

Preparation: 30–45 minutes. Bring one draft comment using issue, consequence and a feasible action.

- Which controls and observation counts change across Table 2?
- What would a comparison on the same countries clarify, and what would it leave unresolved?
- What assumptions would be needed to turn a conditional association into a causal claim?

Lecture 8: Friday 30 October

Law and Economics focus: experimental evidence on sanctions, competing behavioural mechanisms and the limits of policy conclusions.

Gneezy and Rustichini (2000), same paper, second reading

[Read the paper](#)

Revisit Section II, Table 1 and Figure 1. Read the prose in Section IV.A and IV.D (skip IV.B and IV.C), Section V and Appendix A. Appendix B is optional and will not be reproduced in class.

Preparation: 30–45 minutes. Bring one strength and two specific comments; also bring a result and one comment from your own agreed assessment paper.

- At what level was the fine assigned, and what does that imply for the analysis?
- Does the observed response identify a unique mechanism or distinguish all the proposed explanations?
- What specific claim can the evidence support, and what would you ask the authors to clarify?